

Louis Kahn

Noted for his expressive use of concrete and brick, Louis I. Kahn (1901–74) was one of the leading American architects of the 20th century. First opening his practice in 1935, he took a professorship at Yale in 1947. In 1950–1, inspired by a term as architect in residence at the American Academy in Rome, he began to mix the solid forms and stable materials of antiquity with modern innovations; the results can be seen in, for instance, the barrel-vaulted ceilings of the Kimbell Art Museum, Texas (opposite, 1966–72). The campus of the Salk Institute for Biological Studies in San Diego (1962–3) is arguably his masterpiece: a complex of buildings in pinkish concrete (mixed to an old Roman recipe), separated by a stream of water coursing through a serene plaza, it was designated an historic landmark in 1991. Major projects on the Indian subcontinent included the National Assembly Building of Bangladesh in Dhaka (1962–83), a remarkable geometric design that maximizes natural light in all parts of the building including the vast parliament chamber.

